Thursday, January 4, 2024
Poush 19, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Thingalaga Astami

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 19 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

National authority to steer reconstruction works

PM concerned over delay in delivery of temporary shelter budget

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA), one of the government units under the Ministry of Home Affairs, would be given all the responsibility of the reconstruction works of private and government infrastructures damaged in Jajarkot and Rukum West by the November 3 earthquake.

Prime Minister Prachanda made this remark while addressing an extensive interaction programme organised by the province and local level governments of Karnali and Sudurpaschim provinces to collect suggestions and attain concrete model for the reconstruction of quake-hit Jajarkot, Rukum West, Salyan and other districts that were struck by the November 3 quake in the Capital on Wednesday.

He said that for the purpose, the government, especially the Office of Prime Minister and Council of Ministers (OPMCM), is focusing its concern to amend the Act and change the organisational structure and the management of NDRRMA to make it stronger, more effective, and well-resourced.

Prime Minister Prachanda said the government has not thought about establishing a separate body like Reconstruction Authority that was established in the wake of 2015 earthquake.

Similarly, the Prime Minister has said that the state's mechanism is deeply rooted and based on completing many formalities rather than delivering result-oriented works in immediate way to any kind of disaster victims.

Prime Minister Prachanda said when the Cabinet decided to provide Rs. 50,000 as relief amount for the construction of temporary shelter in Jajarkot and Rukum West, the secretaries of the government have told him that the budget for the purpose can be sent to the accounts of the local governments through the provincial level within two days, but as of now, the allocated budget has not reached the victims' hand even after the lapse of two months.

"All these things have been happening due to our procedural arrangements made in the Act, regulation and policies and now these procedural hassles will be removed within my term," said the Prime Minister.

"I told the bureaucrats, 'let's arrange for sending the Rs. 50,000 relief amount within two hours of the Jajarkot quake,' but still, I'm in shock that the amount has not yet reached the hands of victims even after two months of the disaster," said Prime Minister Prachanda.

This the time of digital technology and the government itself is talking about implementation of e-governance, but why we can't implement such things when the nation is hit by disasters like earthquake, COVID-19 and other such pandemic situations, Prime Minister Prachanda questioned.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressing an interaction programme on reconstruction of affected area of November 3 Jajarkot earthquake held in Lalitpur on Wednesday.

NOVEMBER 3 JAJARKOT EARTHQUAKE

Prime Minister Prachanda has also said that the government arranged Rs. 10 billion for the quake victims and this budget is still insufficient. "When the government arranged the fund of Rs. 10 billion at our own initiative, now, we can ask for providing additional fund from our donor partners including the World Bank for the reconstruction," he said.

"The more provincial and the local level governments get active in this reconstruction task, the more the victims would be able to get new houses in time that were damaged by the quake," Prime Minister Prachanda said.

He also said that all three-tier governments this time were able to act promptly and organised way in comparison with the Gorkha quake of 2015.

Prime Minister Prachanda said that reconstruction model should be based on the cultural and social aspects of the concerned geography or location of the country so that they can own their new infrastructure by learning lessons from the reconstruction models that were adopted and latter failed after locals denied taking shelter there.

He said that the fruitfulness and necessity of federalism as envisaged by the constitution can be felt in such a time when the nation faces mega disasters as the province and local levels can act and move into action immediately for the service of people.

Also, Minister for Finance Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat said that the federal government would not create a situation of non-availability of budget for the reconstruction and temporary shelters for the quake victims of Karnali and Sudurpaschim provinces.

"We do manage budget at any cost and our donor partners are also positive in arranging budget for the same purpose very soon," Minister Mahat said.

As per the preliminary figure given by the NDRRMA to the government, it has been estimated that it costs Rs. 70 billion to Rs. 75 billion for conducting reconstruction works in the two provinces of the quake-hit districts, Minister Mahat said.

Anil Pokhrel, Chief Executive Officer of the NNDRRMA, said that of the total Rs. 10 billion budget decided to be released for the temporary shelters, the government has just now released Rs. 2 billion.

CEO Pokhrel said that earthquake victims residing in Masta Rural Municipality of Bajhang district have not been able to get a single tranche of relief amount yet nor build any temporary shelter there as there is no government official to sign in the cheque for its release order. This has been happening because of our lengthy government procedure in bureaucracy, he said.

Natural disaster risk management expert Dr. Gangalal Tuladhar also said that there has been direct and indirect non-cooperation from the Disaster and Conflict Management Division under the Ministry of Home Affairs to the NDRRMA for its full and autonomous functioning since its establishment. Dr. Tuladhar suggested the government to scrap the division when the government has already established NDRRMA and make it stronger and more effective handing it over more power by arranging laws. He also suggested the government to bring NDRRMA under the PMO office for its full functioning by arranging one executive vice-chairman at the Authority.

Janardan Sharma, lawmaker of CPN-Maoist from Rukum West, said that the quake victims of the province are currently waiting for concrete reconstruction model and planning and they have been asking for the lawmakers and the government repeatedly. "We have been providing relief package and budget just for constructing temporary shelters and reconstruction of private houses but, construction of toilets, and roofing, and management of safe drinking water and sheds for livestock could not be managed yet," said Sharma.

On the occasion, mayor Chandra Prakash Gharti of Bheri Municipality, Rabi K.C., mayor of Aathbiskot Municipality of Rukum, and CDOs Hari Prasad Pantha of Rukum West and Suresh Sunar of Jajarkot presented their working papers on the overall scenario of earthquake victims in the districts.

The programme was chaired by mayor Ratna Bahadur Khadka of Chhedagaad Municipality, Jajarkot.

Role of engineers vital to achieve prosperity

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has called engineers vital pillar for nation-building.

Addressing the 16th National Convention of Engineers organised in Kathmandu on Wednesday, Prime Minister Prachanda highlighted the important role of engineers and technical manpower played in developing the nation's infrastructure, factories, agriculture, tourism and energy.

"Development and engineering go hand in hand," he said, adding, "Prosperity can only be meaningfully realised if the role of engineers is enhanced."

The Prime Minister also said that only technically able human resources could help the nation obtain results from development projects. "Development is admittedly a long and complicated process. But we cannot help but feel that we are in a situation where disputes and controversies prolong a project's completion period and financially burden the state," he said.

"We can bring happiness to the people's faces only if we speed up our work and deliver results on time, which is only possible with your technical expertise," he emphasised.

But, at the same time, Prime Minister Prachanda asked engineers to be mindful of the environmental impact of their activities. "The structures your creativity and skills create should prove useful to humanity. But, rapid development and construction adversely affect nature, as is currently being seen in Nepal," he told everyone at the event.

On the occasion, he said that Nepali politics had come out of its transitional period and was moving towards stability. In his words, the nation's political parties now had the challenge and opportunity to fulfil their commitments and promises.

In this regard, he stated that the present government was working to ensure social justice and good governance. "The first year of my third term was focused on controlling corruption, guaranteeing good governance and addressing economic challenges."

He also shared his belief that the nation needed good, not big, people to develop.

Noting the Nepal Engineers' Association's demand for the establishment of a staff college to support the capacity building of engineers, the Prime Minister clarified that the government would make an effort to set up such an institution.

Nepal-India Joint Commission meeting to begin today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

The Seventh Meeting of the Nepal-India Joint Commission, a high-level mechanism between the two countries is being held in Kathmandu on January 4 and 5.

The Joint Commission Meeting will review the overall state of bilateral relations and various areas of mutual cooperation, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) said in a statement on Wednesday.

Minister for Foreign Affairs of Nepal, NP Saud, and Minister for External Affairs of India, Dr. Subrahmanyam Jaishankar, will co-chair the Meeting, leading their respective delegations.

Dr. Jaishankar is scheduled to arrive in Kathmandu on Thursday at the invitation of FM Saud to participate in the meeting.

During his visit, Minister Dr. Jaishankar will pay courtesy calls on President Ramchandra Paudel and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda.'

FM Saud will also host a dinner in honour of the visiting dignitaries. Dr. Jaishankar will return to India on Friday.

The India-Nepal Joint Commission was established in 1987 and provides a platform for both ministers to review all aspects of the bilateral partnership.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) of India said in a statement that during the visit, Dr. Jaishankar would also call on the leadership of Nepal and meet prominent political figures. "Nepal is a priority partner of India under its 'Neighbourhood First' policy. The visit is in keeping with the tradition of high level exchanges between two close and friendly neighbours," read the statement of the MEA.

The JC meeting will delve into the issues related to border, trade and commerce, economic cooperation, and energy trade. The experts with whom FM Saud solicited suggestions from also suggested that Nepal should give priority to issues like increasing export of goods and electricity to India, constructing and strengthening cross-border infrastructure, timely completion of bilateral projects and opening of the air routes.

SC issues interim order against Phukot Karnali hydel project

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kalikot, Jan. 3

The Supreme Court has issued an interim order not to immediately implement the decision to award the 480-megawatt Phukot Karnali half-reservoir hydropower project to an Indian company.

After a preliminary hearing on the writ filed by Yashoda Kumari Baral and Ajay Bahadur Shahi of Raskot Municipality in Kalikot district, Justice Til Prasad Shrestha issued a short-term interim order not to award the national pride project to the Indian developer till Sunday, January 7.

Petitioner Baral said that a short-term order was obtained to discuss the issues with the defendant to decide whether to grant an interim order.

The writ was filed against 10



government offices, including the Office of the Prime Minister and the Council of Ministers, the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, the Ministry of Finance, the Ministry of Forestry and Environment, the Department of Energy Development, Nepal Electricity Authority, Power Generation Company Limited and the office of the Phukot Karnali Hydropower Project.

» SEE PAGE 6

Amid biting cold, quake victims still in tents

BY RAJU LAMICHHANE
Musikot, Jan. 3

Even after two months have passed since an earthquake struck Jajarkot, many victims are still compelled to reside under tents.

A total of 53 people from Rukum Paschim lost their lives in the earthquake, leaving around 32,000 families homeless.

Following the earthquake on November 3, 2023, search, rescue, treatment, and relief distribution efforts have been effective.

However, there has been a delay in the construction of temporary housing, prompting complaints from earthquake victims who are forced to stay in tents for months. In this situation, the local government is still focusing on constructing temporary housing.

According to the statistics of the District Administration Office, only 7,079 temporary houses have been constructed in Rukum West with government subsidies so far. The rest of the victims are still living under the tents,



while some are forced to live in houses damaged by the earthquake.

Ramesh Malla of Aathbiskot Municipality-13 said that he, along with most of his family, is currently residing in tents. Some victims have begun moving back to their damaged houses as the tents are unable to withstand the cold. The earthquake victims are eagerly awaiting the construction of temporary houses and the reconstruction of their old homes.

Saraswati Jaisi, another victim from Chhepare village in Aathbiskot Municipality-14, expressed concerns about the rising health issues affecting all families staying in the tents.

She mentioned that the winter cold seeps into the tents, exacerbating her own struggles with cold-related discomfort and asthma. She urged the government to expedite house construction, emphasizing that it would provide much-needed relief to the affected individuals.

Chief District Officer Hari Prasad Pant informed that a total of 7,079 temporary houses have been constructed, and an additional 9,341 houses are currently under construction.

So far, the district has received a budget of Rs. 840 million from the federal government for temporary housing construction. A sum of Rs. 590 million from the district has already been sent to the local-level fund as the first installment.

To date, the local level has disbursed Rs. 49.2 million into the accounts of beneficiaries. A total of 19,717 families have received the initial installment at the rate of Rs. 25,000 each.

So far, about 27,000 beneficiaries have been identified in the district, while the work of collecting applications is still going on at the local level. It is estimated that the number of beneficiaries will reach about 32,000.

Nepal achieves tourism target, but yet to reach pre-COVID level

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

Nepal met its target of bringing 1 million tourists into the country in 2023 but failed to surpass pre-COVID numbers. As per a statement issued by the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (MoCTCA) on Tuesday, Nepal welcomed 1,014,871 foreign tourists from January to December last year. This is more than the numbers Nepal recorded in 2020, 2021 and 2022 combined.

In 2020, the year the coronavirus outbreak hit Nepal and much of the world, 230,085 foreigners visited the country. This number dropped further in 2021 when only 150,962 foreign nationals came. In 2022, the figure rose to 614,869.

Last year though, tourist arrivals shot up by 65 per cent and crossed the 1 million mark for the first time since the COVID-19 pandemic. In the same period, Nepal welcomed an all-time high number of Indian tourists. As per the data compiled by the Department of Immigration, over 319,000 Indians came to Nepal by air. Indians coming by land are not counted as tourists. This number is well over the 254,000 Indian nationals that came four years earlier before the world knew COVID.

In its statement, MoCTCA called it an important achievement for Nepal's tourism sector and attributed the "success" to efforts made by the government, the private sector, the Nepali embassies abroad and all the concerned stakeholders.

Furthermore, the ministry informed that its minister Sudan Kirati had written to heads of Nepal's missions in various countries, asking them to support the Visit Nepal Decade 2023-2032 and help the country attract 3.5 million tourists from across the world.

But, as encouraging as 2023's tally is, it is still, when viewed as a whole, below the 1,197,191 visitors Nepal received in 2019. The total tourist arrival the country saw last year is 15 per cent less than the arrival it witnessed in the year immediately before countries across the globe closed their borders due to the novel coronavirus.

Meanwhile, the Bagmati Province government has launched the Visit Bagmati Year (VBY) 2024 campaign. Informing about the commencement of the campaign on Monday, the province's Minister for Culture, Tourism and Co-operatives Pukar Maharjan said that various programmes would be held in Bagmati throughout this year to attract visitors.

He also added that the goal of VBY was to exploit the province's tourism potential and establish the sector as a strong source of income.

Stating that the province government would make the required policies and infrastructure for tourism promotion, Minister Maharjan said that the VBY had been announced to identify tourist destinations of the province and publicise places of religious, historical and natural importance.

Also speaking at the event, Secretary at the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Co-operatives Gobinda Prasad Rijal informed that the provincial government had allocated Rs. 10 million to conduct various tourism-related activities this fiscal year.



PHOTO: TRN

Tourists observing pashmina products in Kathmandu on Wednesday.

RIVER GUIDES CALL FOR WAGE INCREASE

RSS
Muglin (Chitwan), Jan. 3

River guides have demanded an increase in wages, stating that their daily wage should be at least 3000. The 15th annual general meeting of the Himalayan Riverguide Association of Nepal (HIRGAN) held at Fishling of Ichchakamana-3 in Chitwan decided that the minimum daily wage of a river guide should be Rs 3,000.

The river guides are currently getting a daily wage of Rs 2,500 and the AGM has decided to demand that the daily wages of river guides be Rs 4,000 if they have to travel for several days, said the vice president of HIRGAN, Dol Bahadur Gurung.

Milan Gurung of Chitwan, who has been working as a river guide for a long time, said that since they have to work from morning till late at night an increase in the wages is being demanded. Furthermore, it is difficult to make a daily living because of the income only in during the season for water-based tourism activities.

Meanwhile, the River guides have also demanded to stop the construction of Trishuli Hydro Power Project under-construction in Trishuli River. The project will affect the employment of more than 150 river guides.

The HIRGAN believes that the beauty of the Trishuli river, which is considered the best in the world for water voyage, will deteriorate and the livelihood of the water travel operators and the workers dependent on it will be taken away.

The Association plans to organize various programs to put forth its demands, including drawing attention of the relevant agencies.

TRS Atlas to operate Nepalgunj ICP

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

Nepal Intermodal Transport Development Board (NITDB) informed that the Integrated Check Post (ICP) at the Nepal-India border in Nepalgunj will be operated by TRS Atlas Logipark Pvt. Ltd, managed by Atlas Terminial JV.

Issuing a statement on Wednesday, the agency under the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies, said that two companies, Atlas and Trans Nepal Freight Services Pvt. Ltd. had participated in the bidding process to obtain the management of the ICP. The agreement with the company was signed on November 8, 2023.

The company will operate the trade facility for five years from the date of handover and will pay Rs. 208.8 million in rent to the government while the fees and charges will be shared as per the rules.

Ashish Gajurel, Executive Director of the NITDB, said that currently Nepal has eight ports and all have been handed over to the private sector for management and operation.

When he joined the Board three years ago, there were six ports under the NITDB and four of them were being operated and managed by the private sector and the remaining two were managed by the Board itself. "The ports have been successfully operated by the private sector through the public private partnership (PPP) model," said Gajurel.

The NITDB had called for a bid to operate the ICP in Nepalgunj in June last year. The ICP was developed with the economic and technical cooperation of India. However, water tank, CCTV, networking, and fire-fighting system are still under construction.

The facility was jointly inaugurated virtually by the prime ministers of Nepal and India, Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and Narendra Modi during the former's visit to India in May-June 2023.

REMITTANCE LITERACY SCHEME LAUNCHED

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

Remittance service provider company IME has orgnised remittance literacy programmes in all seven provinces to raise awareness among the stakeholders and people. "Business partners and people from each province enthusiastically attended the event, which was conducted in all seven provinces since mid-November 2023," the company said in a statement on Wednesday.

The literacy programmes were focused on remittance and its usage, safe transfer of the amount received as remittance, attention needed by the customer while sending and receiving money, and digital remittance services.

According to the company, since its inception, IME has been committed to bringing remittance services to the reach of every Nepali, to protect workers in foreign employment and self-employed service clients abroad, as well as their hard-earned money at home.

CNI, AmCham sign MoU to enhance business between Nepal, America

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

A memorandum of understanding (MoU) has been signed between the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) and the American Chambers of Commerce in Nepal (AmCham) to promote investment and strengthen business environment between Nepal and America.

According to the agreement, the two organisations will work as a centre of contact between Nepalis and American entrepreneurs, provide investment information to American investors willing to invest in Nepal and cooperate in advocating policy reforms to meet mutual objectives.

Both the institutions will conduct strategic activities to increase American investment in Nepal, according to a press statement of CNI. It is mentioned in the MoU to work on improving the investment and business environment for the IT sector by increasing access to market-based financial and non-financial services.

> American Chambers of Commerce Nepal (AmCham) is an umbrella organisation of businesses operating in Nepal with American investment. In the programme, CNI president Agrawal said that this collaboration would serve as a bridge to connect Nepal and America commercially.

President of CNI Rajesh Kumar Agrawal and President of American Chamber of Commerce Nirmal Kajee Shrestha signed the memorandum of understanding in a programme held at the CNI secretariat on Tuesday.

American Chambers of Commerce Nepal (AmCham) is an umbrella organisation of businesses operating in Nepal with American investment. In the programme, CNI president Agrawal said that this collaboration would serve as a bridge to connect Nepal and America commercially.

He expressed his hope that the MoU would help to exchange knowledge and skills, to open new avenues for innovation and collaboration, compete in the global market, attract foreign investment, and contribute to industrial development.

President of AmCham Shrestha said that cooperation with the CNI would work effectively for the development of the country's economy by increasing American investment in Nepal.

FNCCI, govt sign MoU to promote cottage, small industries

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

The Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) and Centre for the Promotion of Cottage and Small Industries of the Government of Nepal signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to forge partnership and cooperation for promoting cottage and small industries in Nepal.

The MoU was signed by Gokarna Raj Awasthi, Director General of the FNCCI, and Deepak Ghimire, Executive Director of the Centre.

According to the agreement, partnership and cooperation programmes will be conducted in the field of promotion of cottage and small industries in cooperation of both organisations.

The two organisations will actively cooperate with each other to make the government announced programmes in this sector successful.

The federation will facilitate the implementation of workplace-based employment training programmes while both the organisations will cooperate to transfer skills and technology necessary to promote cottage and small industries.

Speaking at the MoU signing programme, Vice-president of the FNCCI, Sur Krishna Vaidya, expressed the commitment that the business organisation, which has a large network of industrialists and businessmen, will work in cooperation with the government in the development of cottage and small industries in the country and that they will move ahead together for the development and promotion of this sector in the future.

Similarly, Ghimire expressed his belief that the programmes of the centre would be successful when working together with the FNCCI.

Dharan to hold establishment festival

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dharan, Jan. 3

Dharan Sub-metropolitan City has decided to organise a five-day festival to celebrate its establishment day. Speaking at a press conference on Wednesday, Mayor of Dharan, Harka Raj Rai, said that Dharan Festival will include various programmes at the public school playground from 5-9 January. The sub-metropolis celebrated the Umanagara Palika has been celebrating the 5th of January every year as the Dharan Day.

The sub-metropolis will organise a cleanup programme from Himalaya Petrol Pump to Tinkune, a day before the Day, said Rai. According to him, on the first day of the five-day Dharan festival, a rally and opening ceremony of the festival will be held. He informed that honours and awards will be distributed through cooperative activities at the opening ceremony.

Similarly, cycling and literary honour programme will be organised on January 6, walkathon on 7, school level sports competition and folk recitation programme, labour contribution and exhibitions on January 8, and investment seminar on January 9. On the last day of the festival, tug of war competition, and distribution of appreciation letter will also be organised.

During the festival period, health-related activities will be free of charge, and cultural programmes and public awareness activities on sanitation will be organised, said Mayor Rai.



PHOTO: BISHNU POKHAREL/TRN

Farmer Karna Bahadur Gurung of Kamal Rural Municipality-2 has grown cassava (Simal Tarul) measuring 8 feet and weighing 16 kilograms on his farm.

MINISTRY ISSUES ALERT ON NEW COVID VARIANT RISK

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

The Ministry of Health and Population has issued a notice warning the public about the risk of transmission of JN.1 sub-variant of coronavirus. The notice states that the newly discovered sub-variant JN.1 strain is of great concern since it has been found spreading rapidly in neighbouring countries.

The ministry informed that the new variant has not yet been found in Nepal, and it is taking preventive measures and monitoring all activities in the neighbouring countries.

According to the ministry, considering the risk of JN. 1 sub-variant, all health desks, medical service providers and authorities have been alerted and notified to conduct screening and testing at every border point.

Similarly, the ministry has urged all citizens to follow COVID-19 health protocols including wearing masks and maintaining social distance while attending a fair, party, social event and gathering as well as maintaining hygiene by washing hands.

Kalpana, the lone woman auto-rickshaw driver of Jumla

BY NETRA SHAHI
Jumla, Jan. 3

The winter mornings are unforgivingly cold. Water is untouchable and the frigid air is much too happy to stab any part of the body left uncovered. No ordinary person dares brave these conditions, but Kalpana Budha looks an extraordinary person.

Every day, at the crack of dawn, the 30-year-old originally hailing from Patarasi Rural Municipality-7 leaves her home with her trusty auto rickshaw. Then, till evening, she ferries passengers around Chandannath Municipality.

These days, it is easy. Many know her and, as possibly Jumla's only female auto driver, support her. But the conditions that brought her here were anything but. Kalpana was born to a postman father named Bhairav Bahadur Budha who, after she completed the fourth grade from the Maharudra Basic School at Patmara, sent his daughter to the district headquarters Khalanga to study at Saraswoti Secondary School.

In the seventh grade, when she was only 13 years old, Kalpana married a boy named Ratan who was from the same village as her. Four years later, she gave birth to a son. But 17 days after that, Ratan ran off to India with another woman. He has still not returned. This left Kalpana helpless. She moved in with her parents and did whatever she could to provide for her child.

Then, five years ago, her brother Suvash encouraged her to begin driving auto rickshaws. Suvash is a former drug addict who now runs a rehabilitation centre in Khalanga to help other addicts recover. Her brother's motivation prompted Kalpana to go to Surkhet and learn to drive autos. But then came the question of acquiring an auto. "I had learnt to drive but had no money to buy an auto rickshaw," she said. "Thankfully, my family stepped in," recalling the moment almost brought tears to her eyes.

Every member of Kalpana's maternal family, her parents, sister, brother and sister-in-law, gave what they could. This allowed her to purchase an auto with a down payment of Rs. 300,000. "I have not had to look back since."

In the last half a decade, Kalpana has become quite popular in Chandannath. People wait to get on her rickshaw and some days she is so busy that she does not even have time for food. Through her vehicle, Kalpana makes around Rs. 30,000 a month. She uses this money to educate her son, who is 12 years old now, and fulfil his needs. She wants to buy a four-wheeler now to be able to carry more passengers but health problems have been siphoning her money lately.



PHOTO: NETRA SHAHI/TRN
Kalpana Budha in waiting for the passenger in her auto-rickshaw for a ride.

"I was not really comfortable with this occupation at first. But now, I am happy," she said. Bhairav Bahadur is also glad that his daughter is earning both name and money.

Dil Maya Shahi, vice president of the Federation of Nepali Journalists' Jumla chapter, called Kalpana an exemplary woman who has proven that women can do anything if given the opportunity.

NEWS BRIEF

Deusi money to quake victims

Nepalgunj: The locals of Pashupatinagar and Amarnagar in Nepalganj-18 have donated Rs. 25,000 collected from playing Deusi-Bhailo in Tihar last year to the earthquake victims of Jajarkot and Rukum West districts.

Tilak Bahadur Giri, the coordinator of the Bhailo Committee, and other officials had deposited the amount into the relief fund account and handed over the voucher to Shrawan Kumar Pokharel, the Chief District Officer of Banke.

The committee had also provided Rs. 5,000 collected from Deusi for the construction of a Shiva Temple in the area. Giri informed that the committee would continue to help those in distress, poor, helpless and children in the future.

Sunsari schools get computers

Inaruwa: Bhokraha Narsingh Rural Municipality in Sunsari distributed computers and digital panel boards to the students of four model schools within the rural municipality under its Educational Reform Programme.

Subarna Ghimire, chief administrative officer, informed that 10 sets of computers and one digital panel board were provided to each Sarada Secondary School in Ward No. 1 and Jamiya Islamiya School in Ward No. 4.

Similarly, the rural municipality Chairman Ajmal Akhtar and Vice-chair Sunita Kumari Urab handed over 10 computer sets to Prithvi Narayan Secondary School in Ward No. 4 and one-panel board to Janata Secondary School in Ward No. 4.

(TRN)

265 gharials counted in Rapti and Narayani rivers

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

A total of 265 gharials (Gavialis gangeticus) have been documented in the Narayani and Rapti rivers. The Gharial count took place from December 17 to December 31, 2023 in both rivers. As per the census, there are 152 gharials in the Rapti River and 113 in the Narayani River.

A total of 10 staff members from Chitwan National Park and the National Trust for Nature Conservation, Sauraha, were deployed for the census of the endangered gharials. Various tools and equipment, including drones, river rafts, GPS devices, cameras, and binoculars were used for the survey.

During the count, three dolphins were also observed. This unexpected discovery adds a valuable dimension to the overall success of the monitoring process, said a press statement issued by Chitwan National Park on Tuesday.



PHOTO: TRN
Gharial seen at the bank of Narayani River on Wednesday.

Cases of severe viral flu high in Nepalgunj

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Jan. 3

Nag informed that now up to 50 patients with severe viral flu are visiting the hospital daily.

Locals of Banke district have been suffering from a severe type of viral flu in recent weeks. Hospitals have reported a surge in the number of patients with cold and viral flu. Since a new variant of Coronavirus, JN.1, has been found in India, doctors have suggested that patients with severe flu should get tested for COVID-19 if they do not recover in a few days.

According to the Health Office Banke, with the fall in temperature, the number of patients with viral flu including fever, cold, pneumonia and diarrhoea has increased in the district.

Naresh Shrestha, information officer at the Health Office of Banke, said that with the free temperature, severe viral flu has been observed in various places of Banke, and the general public has been requested to be alert. "If the patient is not recovering from flu even after a few days, the doctors have been requested to suggest coronavirus testing, and the Nepalgunj sub-metropolitan health department has been requested to increase surveillance at the Nepal-India border point," said Shrestha.

Prakash Nag, Senior Physician in Nepalgunj, said that with the arrival of the winter season, patients are suffering from severe viral infections like high fever, cold, headache, muscle pain, joint pain and sore throat. Nag informed that now up to 50 patients with severe viral flu are visiting the hospital daily.

Dr. Roman Kedwai, Co-Director of Nepalgunj Teaching Hospital, said that many children are also being admitted to the hospital with severe flu. He urged guardians to pay special attention to the care of children throughout the winter.

POLICE MOBILISED TO CONTROL RIVER AGGREGATES

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kanchanpur, Jan. 3

Police have been mobilized to prevent theft of river aggregates in Kanchanpur's Doda, Banhara, Sunwora, Syali and other rivers. As a result, 14 tractors have been detained for illegal extraction of river products so far in the year 2080-081, said Police Inspector Ishwar Thapa of the Area Police Office, Jhalari.

Along with the police, the local residents have also been vigilant to stop the theft of river products and informing police them about the illegal act. Meanwhile, the Division Forest Office has written to the community forest users group under it jurisdiction to stop the illegal collection of river aggregates.

Since information has been received that river products are being illegally taken out from rivers within the community forest area correspondence has been made to stop such activities, said Divisional Officer of Divisional Forest Office, Kanchanpur, Bhim Prasad Kandel.

Basnet organises health camp instead of throwing wedding party

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gulmi, Jan. 3

A journalist from Gulmi has conducted a free health camp from the expenditure of his marriage feast. Mohan Basnet, a resident of Bhadgaun of Rasunga Municipality-3, organised the health camp and provided services to the locals instead of throwing a lavish wedding party.

Basnet, a popular YouTuber, organised the health camp at Bhadgaun Secondary School in his village to send a positive message and discourage the practice of extravagant marriages.

Basnet married Saru Acharya on November 28. They both said that they did not want to make their wedding extravagant, instead they wanted to do some humanitarian service from the money they could save by not throwing a marriage party.

Health workers including Gynecologist Dr. Navin Thiruva of Lumbini Provincial Hospital, Consultant Physician Dr. Shambhu Khanal, Orthopedic and Drug Specialist Dr. Ramesh Aryal and Head and Psychiatry Specialist Dr. Ashim Regmi and health workers provided health services at the camp.

Arrangements were also made for the ECG, blood tests and video X-ray services at the camp. As many as 400 locals received OPD services. Likewise, 49 persons received video X-ray service, 20 got ECG service, 108 underwent sugar tests, 43 got uric acid tests, 22 urine tests and 65 people got blood group tests.

Babu Ram Khatri, ward chairman of Ward No. 3, thanked Basnet for arranging the health camp. Basnet also distributed warm clothes to the differently-abled students of Upallo Tamghas Secondary School a few days ago.



PHOTO: TRN
Locals waiting their turn for medical check-up at health camp.

Hayu's lifestyle undergoes sea change

RSS
Kamalamai (Sindhuli), Jan. 3

Lifestyle of indigenous Hayu communities at Kamalamai Municipality-1 in Sindhuli district has undergone tremendous transformation lately thanks to the state facilities and government's programmes.

There are altogether 120 households of Hayu communities in Dandi Gurase Kopche area in Kamalamai-1. People of this indigenous community has witnessed some socio-economic improvement since the government started providing social security allowance and other basic facilities.

The situation of this near-extinct tribal community that is mostly animist was critical in the past. They did not have any source of income and access to education, roads and electricity facility among others. They only had skills of making bamboo products.

Nain Bahadur Hayu's family did not have enough to eat in the past. They used to feed on yam, and wild roots and tubers, he recalled. "These days yam and roots are scarce in the forests that are also diminishing rapidly," he said.

Guna Bahadur Hayu, leader of the community in Adhamara of Kamalamai-1, shared that the memories of going to forest to collect yam and feed the family were becoming fainter in two decades.

According to him, the Hayu people are now capable to feed themselves. They can send their children to school. Road facilities are being added. Every household has electricity.

As a whole, the lifestyle of Hayu communities is becoming organised largely due to the social security allowance of Rs. 4,000 which they get per month.

There are 1,100 beneficiaries from Hayu community in the locality.

Purnimaya Hayu, an elderly, gushed that her lifestyle was improving due to the government's facility. The woman, whose village was a remote settlement, expressed her happiness that all children of her community go to school.

Pramisa Hayu, an 8th grader, from the community walks two hours every day to reach school. Earlier, she used to go to school walking in a narrow pathway. Although the pathway is still unpaved, roads here have been expanded. In her observation, her village was moving on the path of progress.

Some Hayu youths have been engaged in livestock rearing and agriculture besides making bamboo products. Ward chairperson Naresh Gole shared that works were being done to uplift the lives of the Hayu community. To ensure access to education to everyone in the Hayu community, preparations were afoot to run a secondary school in the locality, he said.

Kamalamai Municipality Mayor Upendra Kumar Pokharel argued that it was the responsibility of the government to preserve the language, religion, values and cultures of the Hayu community.

The municipality was mooting plan to promote the skills and identity of Hayu, he informed.

Uttarganga Power Company Limited
(Subsidiary Company of Nepal Electricity Authority)
Tripureswor, Kathmandu, Nepal
Tel : 01-4153239, E-mail : ugpcl@nea.org.np

Second Notice of Invitation of Sealed Quotations

(Date of Publication : January 04, 2024)

Uttarganga power Company Limited (UGPCL) Re-invites quotation for second time from eligible bidders as per details given below. First notice of this sealed quotation was published on December 15, 2023.

Description	Price of Bid Document	Last Date,Tme submission and Opening of Bid	Bid security Amount and Validity Period	Bank A/C Details
Supply and Delivery of Motorcycle and Scooter (UGPCL-2080/81-SQ-01)	Nrs. 1,000.00	January 19, 2024 at or before 12:00 hrs and 14:00 hrs respectively	Nrs. 29,000.00 and 30 days	Account : Uttarganga Power Company Limited Bank: Kumari Bank Ltd. Putalisadak, Kathmandu Account Number : 0010002369400001

Eligible bidders may obtain further information at the office of Uttarganga Power Company Limited (UGPCL), Tripureswor, UWTC 3rd floor, Kathmandu or may visit PPMO's e-GP i.e www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp under the name of Uttarganga Power Company Limited.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

If the doors of perception were cleansed everything would appear to man as it is, infinite.
- William Blake

EDITORIAL

Women Entrepreneurship

Entrepreneurship is the ability and willingness to develop, organise and run a business enterprise by taking financial risks under various uncertainties in the hope of profit. Entrepreneurship is one of the major factors of the production. It is a driving force for economic progress, innovation, and social development. Enterprises form a strong foundation for economic resilience and growth. Women in Nepal have long been active participants in the economy. Although women have low participation in entrepreneurship landscape of Nepal, their involvement in businesses is on increase in recent years. However, women still face various barriers and challenges that are unique to their gender to fully realise their potential as business leaders, owners and entrepreneurs.

More women entrepreneurs face challenges in business skills, finance, technology, and limited access to resources compared to their male counterparts. In addition to this, absence of institutional and policy support hampers access to finance, business development, and reinforces the situation of gender bias. While many countries including in Africa and Asia-Pacific region have included gender consideration in their trade policies, Nepal is providing the same trade incentives to both males and females. As female proportion exceeds more than half of the total population of the country, development of women entrepreneurship is important for the economic development of the country. Moreover, increased women's participation in business is crucial for sustainable growth and economic resilience of the country.

Focusing on the importance of women entrepreneurship for the economic development of the country, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has asked the Ministry of Women, Children and Senior Citizens to prioritise women entrepreneurship development. As per the news report published in this daily on Wednesday, the Prime Minister has directed concerned officials to work for women entrepreneurship development. He said that women rights could be achieved only if women were financially self-sufficient and instructed the ministry to implement a policy of prioritising industries and businesses run by women.

The Prime Minister called it paramount to acknowledge the role played by Nepali women in bringing about political changes in the country and highlighted the need to take account of their political, economic and social conditions. He further directed the ministry to conduct necessary research and formulate an action plan to realise the rights guaranteed by the constitution. For this, he asked it to prepare a list of policy, structural and programmatic actions to be included in the next fiscal year's policy and programmes and budget. He presented a 14-point directive to the ministry to strengthen its capacity to work for the welfare of women, children and senior citizens from all economic, ethnic and social backgrounds.

Though the government has made some policy incentives to women-led enterprises to increase women's involvement in business, they have not been sufficient to increase their participation in desired level. For lack of institutional support many women-led businesses still operate informally and face constraints in access to loans from banks and financial institutions due to collateral requirements while inadequate technology and marketing knowledge hinder the growth. There are more than 20 institutions and mechanisms for the protection and promotion of women's rights, but none seem to be working for the growth and expansion of women-led enterprises. Therefore, in order to promote women entrepreneurship, the government and the private sector need to work for institutional development and policy supports for the women-led enterprises.

The policy related to trade, investment and credits should have the provision of special treatments for the women and women-led enterprises. In order to promote women entrepreneurship as per the spirit of the direction given by the Prime Minister, the concerned ministries and departments and divisions should work rigorously to formulate women entrepreneur-friendly policy in coordination with associations of the private sector. Moreover, for the promotion of women-led enterprises, the government should introduce the policy of subsidising their products which would enhance their competence in the current globalised market.

Effects Of Parental Pressure On Children

BRITTI ARYAL

Parental pressure is often linked to a parent's perception of success in different areas of life. As a parent, you always want your child to be happy and successful. With this aim, many parents pressure their children to follow their suggested path. The emotional stress parents keep imposing upon their children regarding their academic choices, career choices, socio-cultural choices, or any other life choices, not only makes the children emotionally weak but also affects their mental health. Inappropriate parental pressure carries many health-related consequences for children as they grow up. Enforcing the children to be as human as you want, rather than encouraging them for what they want to do or who they want to be just affects the child's self-esteem. Every child is their person and your definition of happiness and success may not be plausible for your children.

As a parent, you always wish the best for your child and you keep on setting the best goals for them. But your expectations might go beyond your child's capabilities sometimes. Your child might not have an interest in the field you choose for them and this might stress them. Sometimes parents even try to employ their incomplete dreams in their children, making them more anxious. The fear of losing their parent's dream makes children more furious. The feeling of being worthless makes them more tempered and angry, giving rise to various kinds of mental illness. The continuous pressure from the parents regarding various situations negatively affects a kid's psychological as well as physical health, increasing the risk of disorders like depression, sleep deprivation, eating disorders, and many more and every parent needs to understand this.

Comparing your child with others and questioning their ability is wrong. Coercing your child to react in the way other kids react and forcing them to follow the same paths as others makes the child lose their confidence. Academically constraining the school child to do well in all subjects and pass with excellent grades is developing an academic fear in students resulting in self-harm and suicidal thoughts. Every child is different and as a parent, you have to respect your child's decision. Although the pressure is based on good intentions, your child might not catch the way, you share your thoughts. They may have different choices and may react to the situation differently than you might.

So, always try to listen to what your child wants rather than insisting them to behave as per your choices. By taking excessive control over your child, you are snatching your child's opportunity to work for themselves. This just lowers your child's confidence and develops the bad habit of compromising on every work they do. They can never give their whole to any work, lessening their capabilities. For this reason, stop being over-involved in your child's activities. Teach your child the right path.

Teach them what is right and what is wrong in a loving way. But never force them to do anything that they do not want. Try to share your thoughts and dreams with your kids and watch their actions. Accept their choices where they want to be. All parents must learn to encourage their children in their interested field, what they are comfortable with, and what they want to be. Try to understand them and follow them through their journey of life. Children are psychologically sensitive subjects and the undesirable pressure will only make them worry. Try to spend more time with your child to know their interest and validate their feelings.

Virtual Dispute Resolution Platforms

Mukti Rijal



At a time when dispute resolution practitioners in the developed world have started to tap into the potentials of artificial intelligence (AI) in resolving cases, judiciary in Nepal has simply initiated the strategy to introduce ordinary forms of information and communication technology in making court adjudication quick and efficient for an enhanced justice dispensation. The process for fixing court hearing of the cases has been automated (swachalit) recently both in the Supreme Court and high courts as part of digitising justice service delivery management.

By integrating electronic automated processes into judicial system, several benefits like reduction in costs, efficiency in case management and transparency in court proceedings can be effectively secured. A study carried out on behalf of Forum for Women, Law and Development (FWLD) - a civil society organization - not very long back talks about the digitisation of justice initiatives in Nepal that include process reengineering, automation, data collection, e-filing, remote court process and technologies used to digitise, store, and provide access to legal documents and evidences. Moreover, the FWLD study also cautions that online dispute resolution may exacerbate digital divide by aggravating barriers to quality justice outcomes.

Virtual hearing

This is because access to such devices as telephone, television, personal computers must be ensured along with the adequacy and affordability of reliable internet and electricity for effective delivery of services. Needless to say, the COVID-19 pandemic has had a significant impact on the use of technology in the Nepali judiciary. The courts had been compelled to provide limited services during the pandemic that constrained and limited the scope of justice delivery. In order to ensure that justice dispensation process was not seriously constrained and impeded, judiciary developed the video conference directive 2078 and introduced reportedly the process to conduct virtual hearing.

Similarly, various forms of digitised services in judiciary have been initiated which include case management system, publication of daily and weekly cause lists on the website, sharing of details of case processes of the courts through websites and so on. Moreover, precedents, judgments of the court can be accessed online through websites. It thus appears that some initiatives have definitely been embarked in lending technology aided impetus to justice dispensation in the Nepali judiciary. But, corresponding technology aided initiatives seem to be lacking in the realm of alternative dispute resolution such as arbitration and mediation.

In mediation process, neutrals or mediators are referred to as the "third party", but interestingly, internet technology used to aid in dispute resolution is referred to as the "fourth party". The concept of the fourth party suggests that technology changes the communication pattern and power dynamics of the mediation process. It opens up new and imaginative ways for mediators and disputing parties to engage in communication process. Forms of technology that have relevance in online dispute resolution include e-mail, web forums, chat rooms, video conferencing, mobile and smart phone technology, voice over Internet protocol, social networking sites, web maps and so on.

On line dispute resolutions, in fact, challenges the conventional claims of mediation that face-to-face problem-solving is the most effective way to dealing

> Since alternative dispute resolution, especially mediation, has become increasingly popular in Nepal, the mediation act should be revised to uphold and recognise virtual platforms for dispute resolution.

with conflict, to uncover diverse interests and address relational aspects of the conflict. Empirical data doubt on the belief that parties need to sit physically in the same room for interest-based negotiation, deep listening and relational transformation to occur. In fact, some studies suggest that parties may be less positional when they are negotiating via e-mail or online chatting compared to face-to-face setting. Moreover, dispute resolution technology is no longer seen as a tool suitable only for settling e-commerce-generated disputes. It is increasingly used to supplement or replace face-to-face mediation processes especially through the use of tools such as tablets and smart phones.

In cross-border jurisdictions, on line dispute resolution is considered to be affordable and convenient because it minimises, and in some cases eliminates the need for participants to travel and reduces the costs associated with using physical meeting rooms. In terms of practice, on line dispute resolution proceedings may be ad hoc, as in the case of parties settling their dispute through an exchange of e-mails and Skype calls with the assistance of a mediator. Alternatively, they may be institutionalised, as in the case of parties submitting to a set of institutional mediation rules and participating in remote sessions hosted by an institutional platform on the dispute resolution provider's server.

The relative affordability of online dispute resolution compared to traditional forms of cross-border dispute resolution presents a valuable opportunity to expand access to commercial justice for small enterprises in cross-border disputes. However, a challenge exists for the international development of online dispute resolution. It is due to the lack of a coherent infrastructure within which service providers can operate. Given that many on line dispute resolution service providers operate independently as they are not connected with a legal or professional association, there is fragmentation in standards and best practices of mediation service delivery.

Online dispute

Needless to say, United Nations agency called UNCITRAL has recognised the use of online dispute resolution in international mediation practices. In Art 2(2) of the Singapore Mediation Convention, the provision supporting online dispute resolution is clearly spelt out. This provision establishes that the writing requirement for a mediated settlement agreement may be met by electronic communication provided the information is accessible for subsequent reference.

What this means is that where a party seeks to enforce an international mediation agreement resulting from an online dispute resolution procedure in a state party to the Singapore Mediation Convention, the settlement agreement being electronic in nature, is unlikely to present an issue to its enforcement. Since alternative dispute resolution, especially mediation, has become increasingly popular in Nepal, the mediation act should be revised to uphold and recognise virtual platforms for dispute resolution. Furthermore, digital infrastructures need to be strengthened for reliable online dispute resolution services.

(The author is presently associated with Policy Research Institute (PRI) as a senior research fellow. rijalmukti@gmail.com)

Consequences Of Being Reckless

Prof. Bhupa P. Dhamala



There are three types of people in terms of work and responsibility. Some human beings are insincere about their work. Some of them are over-sincere and feel always anxious about their assignments. In between there are many people who like to work moderately with a complacent attitude. The complacent people do not become instrumental in social damage but they cannot make progress in life. Over-sincere people may not be satisfied with their tasks because they are too anxious, which may prove insensible most often. The insincere people are the most dangerous because they harm themselves as well as the whole society. This is more applicable to the people who are assigned the public responsibility. If the people with public responsibility are insincere, they are reckless in their activities.

Public responsibility

Ours is a different time when the functions of the government have changed over the years. Previously, the governments were expected to function much for the people – many tasks ranging from maintaining peace and order to providing facilities at the home door. In welfare states, governments are still engaged in launching activities for social welfare. In capitalistic societies, governments are becoming more like business agencies that want to draw more money from taxation and other means. In the changing context, however, governments around the world are entitled to do mainly two functions – maintaining law and order and levying taxes on wage earners and businesspersons.

Since government employees are civil servants who are assigned the responsibility of working in the best interest of the people, they must be highly responsible persons. Not only government employees, but anybody with public responsibility, such as teachers and doctors must be accountable to the public. If a teacher is insincere, for instance, they may not teach well or not teach at all. The students then will be deprived of the good education that their parents desperately expect in their children. Likewise, if a doctor is insincere, a patient may lose their life.

But this is not only applicable to the public person. In an advanced economy, even a private entrepreneur may have a great impact on society. Some obvious instances are the production of goods, especially agricultural products. If an industry, despite launching solely private entrepreneurship, produces poisonous foodstuff, then that product is detrimental to public health. Sometimes, the production of some commodities may cause a deficit for the manufacturer. If a textile industrialist produces unsaleable goods such as clothes with bad design and color, they may not attract the consumer's attention. In this respect, any act that is conducted by somebody at this time is subject to public scrutiny. So, everybody must be sincere if they want to survive and prosper in today's sophisticated society.

Societies of all advanced cultures are very complex today. Interdependence has grown so much that everything is dependent on everything else. Likewise, every person has to rely on every other person. Just as plants and animals live in symbiotic relationships, so do individual

> Everybody must be sincere if they want to survive and prosper in today's sophisticated society.

human beings and the societies they live in. No matter how hard we try to live separately, we ultimately resort to the company of our fellow beings. In a sense, all human beings today are living in micro-symbiotic relationships. In such a context, everybody must be responsible, otherwise, there will be a disaster in society.

Unfortunately, however, the governments of the powerful countries which can have a greater impact on the rest of world, are not what they are expected to be. The developed countries emit more carbon monoxide which causes air pollution. The advancement in science and technology has more sophisticated home gadgets being produced. The industrial growth has caused global warming that has changed the face of the entire earth. Consequently, the developing nations have suffered.

Some argue that the powerful developed countries have absolutely benefitted from the powerless developing countries. But this is not true. Even the developed countries are insincere about the consequences of their actions. If the whole earth is affected, even the developed countries will suffer because the powerless as well as the powerful countries share the same earth.

The same applies to the individuals also. As the oriental saying goes, a stupid person cuts the trunk of a tree while sitting on the upper branches without knowing what will happen when the tree trunk falls to the ground. Even an innocent child can easily understand what it means to be a stupid person like Kalidas, who later became a famous Sanskrit poet in Sanskrit, was once such a stupid person who did an action that was sure to harm himself.

Reckless actions

The consequences of being reckless are unpleasant. What happens to the passengers if a driver is reckless? What are the consequences of the actions of a druggist who enjoys having drugs that gratify the senses for an instant but gradually decay the whole body? A murderer kills the person whom he hates to take revenge but does not think of the imminent danger of life imprisonment. A rapist commits a crime out of uncontrolled sexual desire without thinking of the possible consequence. These are some of the most conspicuous instances of being reckless. There can be many more such actions that harm the doers themselves. The multimillion-dollar question is why do some people take the risk of being reckless? Psychologists say reckless people have a perverted psychology while sociologists might argue that society makes them as they are. There might be an answer to this question but an inconclusive one.

It may be interesting to conclude this article by referring to a tale told by Shakespeare (1623) in his play Macbeth. Goaded by Lady Macbeth believing in the words of witches that Macbeth will become future the King of Scotland and will not be killed by a man born of a woman, the General kills his own kinsman, King Duncan, for which he loses everything consequently because he does the most sacrilegious act being reckless.

(The author is the chairman of Molung Foundation. bhupadhamala@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 4, 1974

Oil Shortage Affects Tourist Industry

Kathmandu, Jan. 3: The tourist industry in Nepal has been affected by the recent international oil crisis and the subsequent aviation fuel shortage, it is learnt here today.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Prioritise Women-led Industries



I am writing in reference to a news report titled, *"Place women-led industries in priority: PM Prachanda"* which was published on January 2, 2023 in the digital version of this daily.

Certainly, women are half the sky. They make a significant portion of the world which is why it is necessary to empower them.

However, they are discriminated in both personal and professional lives.

Especially in underdeveloped nations like Nepal, women have to face unpaid labour and lack of educational and employment opportunities. This creates impediments for their success.

Thus, Nepal government should prioritise women-led industries so that they can thrive in their businesses.

Along with it, government should encourage women entrepreneurs through grants and incentives.

When women are educated and are independent, their families and communities too are influenced positively. It could lead to higher literacy rate and more women in business.

It is said an educated woman can educate the entire family.

Thus, it is imperative that women are given opportunities to excel in all aspects.

Binita Chaudhary Dang

TAILPIECE

Two lawyers were in a coffee shop talking. One of the lawyers names was Thomas Strange. After a while their conversation became rather morbid, and they started to started to talk about what they were going to have on their tomb stones.

Thomas said the he wasn't going to have his name put on his tomb stone, instead he was going have "Here lies the body of an honest lawyer!!!" "Why are you going to have that?" asked his friend.

"Well", said Thomas, "When people are walking through the cemetery, and they see...Here lies the body of an honest lawyer. They will say "Oh...That's Strange".

Israeli strike kills regional commander of Hamas

AP
Beirut, Jan. 3



PHOTO: AP

Hezbollah Civil defense workers search for body remains, near an apartment building where an apparent Israeli strike Tuesday killed top Hamas political leader Saleh Arouri, in the southern suburb of Beirut that is a Hezbollah stronghold, Lebanon, Wednesday, Jan. 3, 2024.

An apparent Israeli strike in the Lebanese capital of Beirut killed Hamas' No. 2 political leader Tuesday, marking a potentially significant escalation of Israel's war against the militant group and heightening the risk of a wider Middle East conflict.

Saleh Arouri, who was the most senior Hamas figure killed since the war with Israel began, was also a founder of the group's military wing. His death could provoke major retaliation by Lebanon's powerful Hezbollah militia.

The strike hit an apartment in a building in a Shiite district of Beirut that is a Hezbollah stronghold, and Hezbollah leader Sayyed Hassan Nasrallah has vowed to strike back against any Israeli targeting of Palestinian officials in Lebanon.

Hezbollah and the Israeli military have been exchanging fire almost daily over the Israeli-Lebanese border since Israel's military campaign in Gaza began nearly three months ago. But so far the Lebanese group has appeared reluctant to dramatically escalate the fighting. A significant response now could send the conflict spiralling into all-out war on Israel's northern border.

Lebanon's state-run National News Agency said the strike was carried out by an Israeli drone, and Israeli officials declined to comment. Speaking to reporters, Israeli military spokesman Rear Adm. Daniel Hagari did not directly mention Arouri's death but said, "We are focused and remain focused on fighting against Hamas."

"We are on high readiness for any scenario," he added.

The killing comes ahead of a visit to the region by U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken, even as the United States has tried to prevent a spread of the conflict, repeatedly warning Hezbollah — and its regional supporter, Iran — not to escalate the violence.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has vowed to press ahead with the assault in Gaza until Hamas is crushed and the more than 100 hostages still held by the militant group in Gaza are freed, which he has said could take several more months. At the same time, Israeli officials have increasingly warned in recent days of stepped-up action against Hezbollah unless its cross-border fire stops.

Arouri was the deputy of Hamas' supreme political leader, Ismail Haniyeh, and headed the group's presence in the West Bank. He was also a key liaison with Hezbollah.

Tuesday's blast shook a residential building in the Beirut suburb of Musharafieh, killing four people, according to the Lebanese news agency.

Russia pounds Kyiv, Kharkiv with missiles

AFP
Kyiv, Jan. 3

Russia stepped up its missile and drone strikes on Ukraine on Dec. 29 when it launched its largest air attack of the war, killing at least 39 people.

Russia fired scores of missiles and drones at the Ukrainian capital Kyiv and the northeaster city of Kharkiv on Tuesday, killing at least five civilians, wounding dozens and causing widespread damage, officials said.

The third successive day of air strikes on Ukraine followed a warning by President Vladimir Putin on Monday that a Ukrainian air attack on the Russian city of Belgorod, which Moscow said killed 25 civilians, would "not go unpunished".

Smoke belched out of the charred side of a high-rise residential building where Kyiv mayor Vitali Klitschko said missile debris had come crashing down metres away, leaving a crater.

He said an elderly woman had died in an ambulance after being wounded at the site and that 43 other people were hurt. Emergency services said a body had also been recovered on the eighth floor of the damaged building.

"Russia will answer for every life (that it has) taken away," President Volodymyr Zelenskiy said on the Telegram messenger.

Russia stepped up its missile and drone strikes on Ukraine on Dec. 29 when it launched its largest air attack of the war, killing at least 39 people.

Almost two years after Moscow's full-scale invasion, Russia holds swathes of territory in eastern and southern Ukraine, and there is no end in sight to the war. Russia depicts a Ukrainian counteroffensive launched in mid-2023 as a failure, and front lines have changed little in recent months.

Klitschko said gas pipelines had been damaged in Kyiv's Pecherskyi district, and electricity and water had been cut off in several districts of the capital.

Private energy company DTEK was working to restore power, but the outages brought back memories of last winter when Russia pounded the energy grid with missiles, causing frequent power cuts and plunging millions into darkness.

Ukrainian air defences, boosted by supplies from Kyiv's Western allies, downed all 10 incoming "Kinzhal" missiles fired in the latest attack as well as 59 of the 70 cruise missiles and all three Kalibr cruise missiles, army chief General Valeriy Zaluzhnyi said.

Foreign Minister Dmytro Kuleba called on Kyiv's Western allies to accelerate supplies of air defence systems, long-range missiles and combat drones.

In Kharkiv, a 91-year-old woman was killed in a missile attack that left a metres-deep crater near damaged residential buildings, Oleh Synehubov, Kharkiv's regional governor, said.

The volley of missiles was preceded by a drone attack that Ukraine said it had repelled hours earlier.

A married couple were killed and 11 people were hurt in the area outside Kyiv, the regional administration said. A dozen residential buildings and at least 60 cars were also damaged, it said.

Japanese officials begin on-site probe after crash

AP
Tokyo, Jan. 3

Transport officials and police began separate investigations at Tokyo's Haneda Airport on Wednesday, a day after a large passenger plane and a Japanese coast guard aircraft collided on the runway and burst into flames, killing five people.

The accident occurred Tuesday evening when the Japan Airlines flight JAL-516 plane landed on one of Haneda's four runways after the coast guard aircraft — a Bombardier Dash-8 — had also entered, preparing to take off. Both sides said they received a go-ahead from aviation officials.

An orange fireball erupted from the aircraft, and the JAL plane continued down the runway covered in flames while spewing gray smoke. Within 20 minutes, all 379 passengers and crew members slid down emergency chutes and survived. The pilot of the coast guard plane, which exploded, evacuated with injuries but five crew members aboard the coast guard plane were killed.

Transport safety officials were focusing on communication between air traffic control officials and the two aircraft to determine what led to the collision.

Police began a separate probe into possible professional negligence. On Wednesday, Tokyo police said that investigators examined the debris on the runway and were to interview the involved parties.

The Japan Airlines A350 had flown from Shin Chitose airport near the northern Japanese city of Sapporo, and the coast guard Bombardier was preparing to depart for Niigata to deliver relief supplies to residents in the central Japan regions hit by powerful earthquakes on Monday that killed more than 60 people.

On Wednesday, six experts from the Japan Transport Safety Board examined what remained of the aircraft, the board said. TV footage showed the severely damaged A350's wings among the charred, broken parts of fuselages. The smaller coast guard plane looked like a mound of rubble.

Transport safety investigators plan to interview the pilots and officials from both sides, as well as air traffic control officials to find out how the two planes simultaneously ended up on the runway, JTSB said. The two sides had different understandings of their permission to use the runway.

JAL Managing Executive Officer Tadayuki Tsutsumi told a news conference late Tuesday that the A350 was making a "normal entry and landing" on the runway.

Critics of Sheikh Hasina say she threatens democracy

AP
Dhaka, Bangladesh, Jan. 3



PHOTO: AP

Bangladeshi Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina greets the gathering during an interaction with journalists after official election results gave her a third straight term, in Dhaka, Bangladesh, Dec. 31, 2018.

Bangladesh's Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina is facing a general election Sunday, a vote she is all but certain to win. Critics say it could further tighten her grip on power after a 15-year-rule that turned a politician who once fought for democratic freedoms into an increasingly autocratic leader.

Hasina's main rival, the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, is boycotting the polls, claiming her government cannot ensure a fair vote, and making it increasingly likely the 76-year-old premier will secure her fourth consecutive and fifth overall term in office.

Her supporters say Hasina — the longest-serving leader in Bangladesh's history — and her Awami League have given them a country with a growing industry and humming development projects. The stability has staved off military coups that have shaken the young, predominantly Muslim nation strategically located between India and Myanmar.

But Hasina's political life, like her country, began with violence. On Aug. 15, 1975, a group of military officers behind a coup assassinated her father, Sheikh Mujib Rahman, the first leader of independent Bangladesh.

Some say the brutal act, which also killed nearly her entire family, pushed her to consolidate unprecedented power and motivated her throughout her career in politics.

"Hasina has one very powerful quality as a politician — and that is to weaponize trauma," said Avinash Paliwal, a senior lecturer specializing in South Asian strategic affairs at SOAS University of London.

A source who worked closely with Hasina says her ambition was to create the country envisioned by her father, who led the new nation after its forces, aided by India, defeated Pakistan in 1971.

"She felt her father's work was cut short, and that only she could complete it," they told The Associated Press, speaking on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak with the media.

After the assassination, Hasina lived for years in exile in India, then made her way back to Bangladesh and took over the Awami League. But the country's military rulers had her in and out of house detention throughout the 1980s until, after general elections in 1996, she became prime minister for the first time.

What followed was a decades long power struggle between Hasina and former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia, the chief of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, now ailing and under house arrest.

The two women alternated running the country for years in a bitter rivalry that polarized Bangladesh. Hasina has often accused the BNP of courting hard-line extremists that her party, which calls itself moderate and secular, had worked to stamp out. Zia's BNP claims the Awami League is using oppressive tactics to stay in power.

Analysts say that while they project different ideologies, both parties are tainted by a history of electoral violence and politics of retribution.

When Hasina was re-elected in 2008, she fixed her sights on the economy and built infrastructure previously unseen in Bangladesh — power lines that reached remote villages, highways, rail lines and ports, and a garment industry that became one of the world's most competitive.

Harvard president Claudine Gay resigns

AP
Cambridge, Mass., Jan. 3

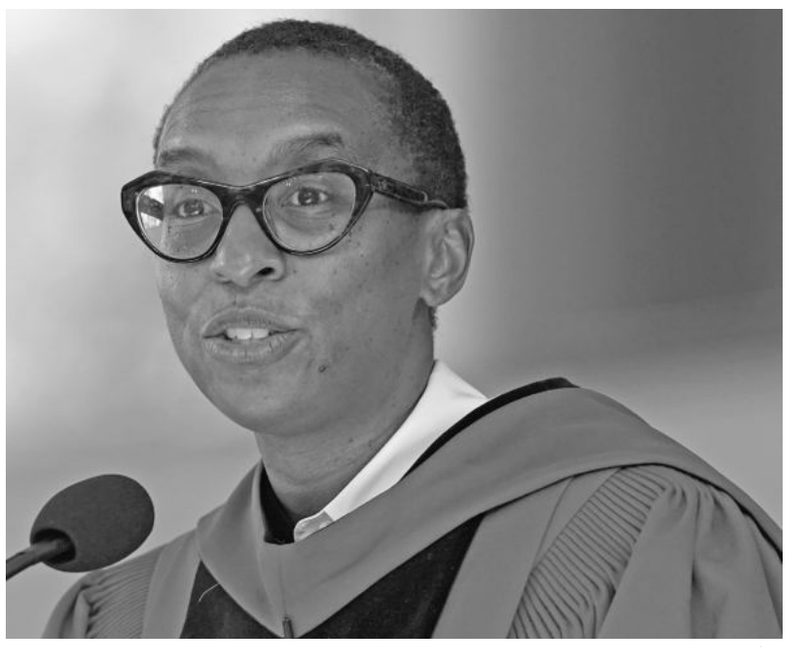


PHOTO: AP

Claudine Gay, Harvard University's president, resigned Tuesday, Jan. 2, 2024.

Harvard University President Claudine Gay resigned Tuesday amid plagiarism accusations and criticism over testimony at a congressional hearing where she was unable to say unequivocally that calls on campus for the genocide of Jews would violate the school's conduct policy.

Gay is the second Ivy League president to resign in the past month following the congressional testimony — Liz Magill, president of the University of Pennsylvania, resigned Dec. 9.

Gay, Harvard's first Black president, announced her departure just months into her tenure in a letter to the Harvard community.

Following the congressional hearing, Gay's academic career came under intense scrutiny by conservative activists who unearthed several instances of alleged plagiarism in her 1997 doctoral dissertation. The Harvard Corporation, Harvard's governing board, initially rallied behind Gay, saying a review of her scholarly work turned up "a few instances of inadequate citation" but no evidence of research misconduct.

Days later, the Harvard Corporation said it found two additional examples of "duplicative language without appropriate attribution." The board said Gay would update her dissertation and request corrections. The Harvard Corporation said the resignation came "with great sadness" and thanked Gay for her "deep and unwavering commitment to Harvard and to the pursuit of academic excellence."

Alan M. Garber, provost and chief academic officer, will serve as interim president until Harvard finds a replacement, the board said in a statement. Garber, an economist and physician, has served as provost for 12 years.

Gay's resignation was celebrated by the conservatives who put her alleged plagiarism in the national spotlight — with additional plagiarism accusations surfacing as recently as Monday in The Washington Free Beacon, a conservative publication.

Christopher Rufo, an activist who has helped rally the GOP against higher education, said he's "glad she's gone."

"Rather than take responsibility for minimizing antisemitism, committing serial plagiarism, intimidating the free press, and damaging the institution, she calls her critics racist," Rufo said on X, formerly Twitter. "This is the poison" of diversity, equity and inclusion ideology, said Rufo, who has led conservative attacks on DEI both in business and in education.

Gay, in her letter, said it has been "distressing to have doubt cast on my commitments to confronting hate and to upholding scholarly rigor — two bedrock values that are fundamental to who I am — and frightening to be subjected to personal attacks and threats fueled by racial animus."

But Gay, who is returning to the school's faculty, added "it has become clear that it is in the best interests of Harvard for me to resign so that our community can navigate this moment of extraordinary challenge."

Yoel Zimmermann, a visiting research undergrad from Munich, Germany, studying physics at Harvard, said that as a Jewish student he's noticed fellow members of the Jewish community have felt uncomfortable with the climate on campus.

PRISM

New Jersey twins born in separate years

New Jersey: A New Jersey couple welcomed a set of twins who were born not only on different days, but in different years.

Ezra Humphrey was born at 11:48 p.m. Dec. 31 at Virtua Voorhees Hospital in Voorhees, giving him the same birthday as father Billy Humphrey, 36. Fraternal twin Ezekiel was born at 12:28 a.m. Jan. 1.

"I was very excited [about] the potential of having my boys on my birthday," Billy Humphrey told Good Morning America. "We went in that day and I wasn't quite sure if they're going to come today or not, but having one of them at least on my birthday was a huge blessing and a gift."

Monkey escapes sanctuary to look for love

Ireland: A capuchin monkey who escaped from a sanctuary in Ireland is likely on the hunt for a mate, the sanctuary's owner said.

Willie Heffernan, owner of Rathdrum Monkey Sanctuary, said the monkey, named Charlie, was being relocated from the island where he resides when he jumped off the boat and fled.

Charlie was 2 years old when he was rescued from an Edinburgh, Scotland, laboratory about 20 years ago, and Heffernan said he decided to relocate the monkey because he had recently started harassing a trio of female monkeys who are all over age 60.

Heffernan said Charlie is likely on the search for a younger mate.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1477 – Battle of Nancy: Charles the Bold is defeated and killed in a conflict with René II, Duke of Lorraine; Burgundy subsequently becomes part of France.
1781 – American Revolutionary War: Richmond, Virginia, is burned by British naval forces led by former American general Benedict Arnold.
1822 – The government of Central America votes for total annexation to the First Mexican Empire.
1875 – The Palais Garnier, one of the most famous opera houses in the world, is inaugurated in Paris.
1900 – Irish nationalist leader John Edward Redmond calls for revolt against British rule.[8]
1911 – Kappa Alpha Psi, the world's third-oldest and largest black fraternity, is founded at Indiana University.
1925 – Nellie Tayloe Ross of Wyoming becomes the first female governor in the United States.



PHOTO: KABITA/TRN

A view of Sep River and the surrounding area on way to Barekot from Jajarkot district headquarters.

Speaker Ghimire requests for Joshi's safe release

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

Speaker Devraj Ghimire has requested to save life of a Nepali youth, Bipin Joshi, who is said to be under the control of Hamas.

During the meeting with Israeli Ambassador to Nepal, Hanan Goder, on Wednesday, Speaker Ghimire requested Goder for the safe release of Joshi.

Stating that efforts are underway to release hostages of other countries including Joshi, Ambassador Goder mentioned that he got the information that Joshi was safe under the Hamas' control, said Speaker Ghimire's secretariat.

On the occasion, discussion was held on various dimensions of Nepal-Israel relations and development of agriculture sector. Ten Nepali students lost their lives in attack by Hamas on October 7 while Joshi was said to be taken captive by Hamas.

We are working to make Madhes corruption-free: CM Yadav

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Janakpurdham, Jan. 3

Madhes Province's Chief Minister Saroj Kumar Yadav has said that the provincial government was working to make Madhes Province free from corruption.

Speaking at a provincial-level interaction programme on corruption control and promotion of good governance organised by the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) in Janakpurdham on Wednesday, Chief Minister Yadav said that the provincial government was committed to assisting the CIAA in the investigation of irregularities in the province.

Speaking at the function, Chief Commissioner of the CIAA Prem Kumar Rai said that mindset and working style should be changed to establish good governance. He emphasised the need for improvements in service delivery to build a corruption-free society.

Meanwhile, it was informed that the CIAA Bardibas office had received complaints against nine ministries including the Office of the Province Chief and the Provincial Assembly of Madhes Province.

As of the record of the CIAA Bardibas till mid-December of the Fiscal Year 2023/2024, a total of 358 cases were registered at the office. Of them, 153 have been resolved while 205 are still pending.

According to the CIAA, the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure Development received the highest number of complaints (169) with 79 of them being dismissed. Meanwhile, the Ministry of Economic Affairs and Law and the Provincial Assembly received the least complaints, one each. The complaint against the Provincial Assembly has been resolved and the one against the Ministry of Economic Affairs is pending.

Similarly, out of 59 complaints registered against the Ministry of Industry, Tourism, Forest and Environment, 19 have been resolved and 40 are pending. In the cases related to the Ministry of Social Development, 26 of 58 complaints have been resolved and 32 are yet to be settled.

The office informed that there were 38 and 26 complaints against the Ministry of Land Management, Agriculture and Cooperatives and the Office of the Chief Minister and Council of Ministers respectively.

Among the districts of Madhes Province, Dhanusha recorded the highest number of complaints at 851 while Sarlahi had the lowest at 501. Similarly, Bara received 699 complaints, Saptari 631, Rautahat 600, Mahottari 588, Parsa 573 and Siraha 536 complaints.

Madhes Province's Chief Minister Saroj Kumar Yadav, Minister for Physical Infrastructure Development Krishna Prasad Yadav, Minister for Land Management, Agriculture and Cooperatives Govinda Bahadur Neupane, Minister for Health and Population Birendra Prasad Singh, Minister for Education and Culture Mahesh Prasad Yadav, Minister for Home, Communication and Law Mohammad Samim and others were present at the interaction programme.

Earlier, on Tuesday, a similar provincial-level interaction programme was conducted in the City Hall of Biratnagar Metropolitan City in Koshi Province.

Speaking at the programme, Chief Minister Kedar Karki said that the CIAA was a collaborative body envisioned by the constitution for controlling corruption and maintaining balance.

He said that good governance and corruption control could only be achieved through collective efforts.

Chief Secretary of Koshi Province Ishwar Kumar Giri said that the employees should perform their duties within the confines of existing laws and regulations to promote good governance and control corruption.

Mahakali corridor: 241-km-long track opened so far in 15 years



RSS
Bedkot (Kanchanpur), Jan. 3

A 241-km-long track has been opened so far along the Kanchanpur-Darchula section under the Mahakali corridor. With this, 93-km-long track is yet to be opened in Dadeldhura, Baitadi and Darchula, said Chief of Mahakali Corridor Project Office, Laxman Dutta Joshi.

"Activities to open the track in the remaining places have been accelerated. We have received order to clear trees. Preparation has been made to blacktop the road where the track is readied", he mentioned, adding that trees along 31-km-long stretch from Simalta-Bhageshwor-Sunarya section of Dadeldhura were being cleared.

For the project, around 2,600 trees need to be cut down in the Dadeldhura section.

Works to open track on 35-km Sunarya-Dogadakedar section of Baitadi are underway while activities are forwarded to clear trees and open track in the remaining area.

The Project Chief further shared that upgrading of 5-km-long road in Dadeldhura will be completed in the current fiscal year.

Total 19,066 trees along the Mahakali corridor should be cut down for the track. It is believed that there would be drastic change in Sudurpaschim Province after the completion of Mahakali corridor. Although the construction activities of Mahakali corridor had started since the fiscal year 2065/66 BS, track of all roads has not been opened yet.

The corridor linking remote areas of Kanchanpur, Dadeldhura and Darchula bordering China would connect more than half areas of hilly areas of Sudurpaschim with Tarai region. Altogether 425- km-long road would be constructed from Kanchanpur to Darchula.

Mahakali Corridor Road Project has been constructing 334-km-long road from Brahmadev to Tusarpani of Darchula while Nepali Army has been opening 91-km-long track from Tusarpani-Tinkar.



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Newly appointed advisor of finance, management and printing Ram Krishna Adhikari (right) and legal advisor Sushila Chaudhary of Gorkhapatra Corporation who assumed their office at the corporation on Wednesday.

Everest Asia Leadership Summit slated for 2025

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3

Asia 4-H Network/4-H Nepal, a youth organisation, on Tuesday announced to hold Everest Asia Leadership Summit 2025.

Organisation chair Lok Raj Awasthi informed in a press statement that over 200 esteemed leaders from more than 30 countries would come together in the summit and discuss the future of leadership shape, climate action and sustainable development in Asia and beyond.

"The Summit is more than just a conference; it's a movement towards a more sustainable and responsible future. The summit's theme, 'Asia's Pinnacle of Leadership Excellence,' reflects our commitment to fostering leadership that not only excels in its vision but also in its dedication to creating a better world," read the statement.

The summit will convene a diverse group of participants, including government representatives, 4-H organisations, business leaders, NGOs, academics, and young emerging leaders, all united by a common goal: to drive positive change.

"4-H Nepal extends a warm invitation to leaders, innovators and visionaries to be a part of this landmark event. Join us in shaping a sustainable and resilient future for Asia and the world," read the statement.

MECHI HIGHWAY REMAINS SHUT DUE TO PROTEST

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ilam, Jan. 3

Vehicular movements along the Mechi Highway came to a complete halt on Wednesday because of the strike called by the pro-identity group, which has been protesting against the naming of Koshi Province since last year.

Four-wheeled vehicles did not ply along the Mechi Highway in Ilam, Jhapa, Panchthar and Taplejung districts since early morning, making the life of commuters difficult.

The agitating group called the Bandh demanding alteration of the name of Koshi Province and to exert pressure on the administration to release their detained activists.

No vehicles of the short and long routes were seen on the road, leaving several passengers stranded at different points of the highway. Different five agitating groups issued a joint press statement calling for the closure of the Mechi Highway on Wednesday and Thursday demanding that the name of Koshi Province be changed.

Dekendra Singh Thegim, president of the 'Province No.1 Re-Nomination Committee', however, said that two-wheelers were not prevented from plying.

A pickup with registration number Me 1 Cha, 1140 was set on fire at Rong Rural Municipality-4, Ilam during a bandh called for December 16 and December 17 last year.

On the charge of setting the vehicle on fire, the police arrested Anjan Rai (Bullet Kirati) of Budhshanti Rural Municipality- 4 of Jhapa. The agitating group said that the fire was not set by their group and demanded the release of Rai.

Iran says at least 103 people killed, 141 wounded in blasts

AP
Dubai, Jan. 3

Two explosions minutes apart Wednesday in Iran targeted a commemoration for a prominent general slain in a U.S. drone strike in 2020, killing at least 103 people and wounding at least 141 others as the Middle East remains on edge over Israel's war on Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

No group immediately claimed responsibility for what Iranian state media called a "terroristic" attack shortly after the blasts in Kerman, about 820 kilometers (510 miles) southeast of the capital, Tehran.

While Israel has carried out attacks in Iran over its nuclear program, it has conducted targeted assassinations, not mass-casualty bombings. Sunni extremist groups including the Islamic State group have conducted large-scale attacks in the past that killed civilians in Shiite-majority Iran, though not in relatively peaceful Kerman.

Iran also has seen mass protests in recent years, including those over the death of 22-year-old Mahsa Amini in 2022. The country also has been targeted by exile groups in attacks dating back to the turmoil surrounding its 1979 Islamic Revolution.

The blasts struck an event marking the fourth anniversary of the killing of Gen. Qassem Soleimani, the head of the Revolutionary Guard's elite Quds Force, who died in a U.S. drone strike in Iraq in January 2020. The explosions occurred near his grave site in Kerman,

Iranian state television quoted Babak Yektaparast, a spokesman for the country's emergency services, for the casualty figure. Authorities said some people were injured while fleeing afterward.

Footage suggested that the second blast occurred some 15 minutes after the first. A delayed second explosion is often used by militants to target emergency personnel responding to the scene and inflict more casualties.

People could be heard screaming in state TV footage.

Kerman's deputy governor, Rahman Jalali, called the attack "terroristic," without elaborating. Iran has multiple foes who could be behind the assault, including exile groups, militant organizations and state actors. Iran has supported Hamas as well as the Lebanese Shiite militia Hezbollah and Yemen's Houthi rebels.

Soleimani was the architect of Iran's regional military activities and is hailed as a national icon among supporters of Iran's theocracy. He also helped secure Syrian President Bashar Assad's government after the 2011 Arab Spring protests against him turned into a civil, and later a regional, war that still rages today.

SC issues interim order...

During Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda's last visit to India, a memorandum of understanding was signed to allow an Indian company to build the Phukot Karnali semi-reservoir project.

Likewise, an agreement was reached in March last year to give 51 per cent stake of Phukot Karnali to the Indian company NHPC. Baral said that the agreement should be revised and the majority of the shares should be in with the Nepali company and a certain amount of the shares should be distributed to the local people as well.

As the writ petitioner demanded the cancellation of 51 per cent shares given to the Indian company during the Prime Minister's visit to India, the court has summoned both sides on the issue of whether or not to issue a mandamus in the name of the government.

The gross head of this project to be built on the Karnali River is 168.62 metres and the design discharge is 348 cubic meters per second. It is mentioned that after the construction of the project, electricity can be produced at full capacity for six hours a day during the dry season.

The electricity generated from the project will be connected to Nepal's national transmission system through a 400 kV double-circuit transmission line.

Electricity can be produced at Rs. 92 billion in five years by constructing a 13-km tunnel.

Yash Kumar's latest release focus on love beyond castes

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 3



Singer Yash Kumar has released another love song 'Timi Chhau Ra Ta', featuring lyrics, music, and vocals by himself.

He unveiled the music video during a programme held in the capital on Tuesday in the presence of the Minister for Culture, Tourism, and Civil Aviation, Sudan Kirati.

Speaking about the song, Minister Kirati expressed discomfort while watching the music video, citing its depiction of a societal story.

Nevertheless, he emphasised the role of music in fostering positivity, societal improvement and contributing to overall domestic production.

Minister Kirati acknowledged the influence of Nepali music and cinema in attracting tourists to regions like Manang and Mustang, proposing that it could develop into a significant industry. He expressed gratitude to those promoting music and cinema, attributing their efforts to the influx of more than 10 million tourists into Nepal.

The Minister was particularly impressed with the life story of singer Yash Kumar, referring to him as a 'sand flower' and commending his journey from childhood struggles, such as collecting sand by the riverside to his current success.

Yash Kumar, in turn, emphasised his commitment to conveying meaningful messages through music, aiming to positively impact society.

Singer Kumar said that the theme of love transcends caste boundaries in his song 'Timi Chhau Ra Ta'.

The musical movie portrays a love story between a Brahmin youth and a Limbu girl, aiming to highlight the universality of love. The music video features performances by Anu Thapa, Prem Subba, Rajesh Ghatani and other actors alongside Yash Kumar.

Sanskriti Sharma wins children's dance idol

=BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Banke, Jan. 3



Sanskriti Sharma from Banke district emerged as the winner in the state-level children's dance idol competition at the Lumbini state-level festival held in Nepalgunj.

According to senior dance director KB Shahi, in the 11-day dance competition, Grishma Rana, Sushmita Sharma and Ponita Sunar secured the second, third and fourth positions respectively.

The competition featured 39 talented children from various districts within the province.

Sharma received a prize of Rs. 30,000, while Grishma Rana and Sushmita Sharma received Rs. 20,000 and Rs. 10,000, respectively.

Likewise, Ponita Sunar, who secured the fourth position, was awarded Rs. 5,000. In addition to the cash prizes, all winners were honoured with trophies and certificates, informed dance director KB Shahi.

Steven Yeun leaves Marvel's 'Thunderbolts'

AGENCIES
Los Angeles, Jan. 3

Hollywood actor Steven Yeun has left from the upcoming Marvel Cinematic Universe (MCU) film 'Thunderbolts'.

The movie, unveiled at Disney's D23 Expo in 2022, revolves around a group of Marvel antiheroes and supervillains. As per Deadline, scheduling conflicts prompted Yeun's departure from the project.

The film's production faced disruptions caused by the strikes from the Writers Guild of America (WGA) and the Screen Actors Guild-American Federation of Television and Radio Artists (SAG-AFTRA) in 2023.

Yeun, known for his performances in 'The Walking Dead' show and movies such as 'Okja', 'Minari' and 'Nope', was cast for a key role in the Marvel Studios film last February. 'Thunderbolts' will feature an ensemble cast of Florence Pugh, Sebastian Stan, David Harbour, Hannah John-Kamen, Wyatt Russell, Olga Kurylenko and Julia Louis-Dreyfus.

Jake Schreier of 'Paper Towns' fame will direct the film, which is scheduled for release in July 2025. In the Marvel Comics, the Thunderbolts is a team of villains, anti-heroes and reformed baddies.

Yeun was most recently seen in Netflix series 'Beef', co-starring Ali Wong. He will next feature in Oscar-winning director Bong Joon Ho's 'Micky 17', starring Robert Pattinson in the lead, as well as 'Love Me' with Kristen Stewart.

Early Mickey Mouse version will star in horror movies

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 3



The earliest iteration of Mickey Mouse is on a rampage, barely two days in the public domain.

Slashed free of Disney's copyright as of Monday, the iconic character from "Steamboat Willie" is already the focus of two horror films. On Monday, just hours after the 1928 short entered the public domain, a trailer for "Mickey's Mouse Trap" dropped on YouTube. Another yet-to-be-titled film was announced Tuesday.

"Steamboat Willie" featured early versions of both Mickey and Minnie Mouse. Directed by Walt Disney and Ub Iwerks, it was the third cartoon featuring the duo they made but the first to be released. In it, a more menacing Mickey, bearing more resemblance to rat than mouse, captains a boat and makes musical instruments out of other animals.

It's perhaps fitting, then, that the first projects announced are seemingly low-budget and campy slasher movies — and not unprecedented. Winnie the Pooh — sans red shirt — entered the public domain in 2022; scarcely a year later, he was notching up a heavy body count in the microbudget "Winnie the Pooh: Blood and Honey."

In the trailer for "Mickey's Mouse Trap," directed by Jamie Bailey, what appears to be a human in a comically small Mickey mask terrorizes a group of young people at an arcade.

"A place for fun. A place for friends. A place for hunting," text flashed during the trailer reads. "The mouse is out."

"We just wanted to have fun with it all. I mean it's Steamboat Willie's Mickey Mouse murdering people," director Jamie Bailey said in a statement cited by trade publications. "It's ridiculous. We ran with it and had fun doing it and I think it shows."

No release date has been set.

The second movie is from director Steven LaMorte, who previously directed a horror parody of "The Grinch," which is not in the public domain (the movie is thus called "The Mean One").

I was clinically dead: Shreyas Talpade

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Jan. 3

Actor Shreyas Talpade, who recently underwent angioplasty after experiencing a heart attack, opened up about his challenging ordeal. In a recent interview, Shreyas shared that he had never been hospitalized before in his life and emphasized the profound realization that 'jaan hai toh jahaan hai' (health is wealth). Rushed to an Andheri hospital last month, Shreyas revealed that his heart had stopped beating for a full 10 minutes.

Speaking to The Times of India, he disclosed that he was 'clinically dead' during the health crisis. Currently recuperating at home, Shreyas acknowledged his family's history of heart ailments. Despite consistently working since the age of 20, the 47-year-old actor mentioned feeling extremely fatigued due to his hectic schedule in recent months, prompting him to take precautionary measures and undergo several tests.

Recalling the day of the cardiac arrest while working on the ensemble comedy film "Welcome to the Jungle," Shreyas narrated the sudden onset of breathlessness and pain in his left hand during military exercises. He struggled to walk to his vanity van, rushed home, and eventually was taken to the hospital by his wife, Deepti. During the journey, he passed out in traffic, but Deepti sought help, and emergency treatment was administered by doctors. Upon regaining consciousness, Shreyas learned that he had been smiling through the angioplasty and kept apologizing to Deepti for the trouble.

Describing the experience as more than a wake-up call, Shreyas stressed the significance of not taking health for granted, encouraging regular doctor visits. Despite leading a healthy lifestyle with no smoking, rare alcohol consumption, and a balanced diet, he expressed surprise at facing such a health crisis. Mentioning the post-COVID surge in heart issues among healthy young individuals, Shreyas extended gratitude to friends, family, and especially his 'superhuman' wife, Deepti.



HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: You are not alone! Lately, you might feel misunderstood or alone on your journey. While it's okay to fly solo sometimes, the people who love you are likely hoping to spend some time with you.

Taurus: Beep, beep -- that's your cosmic alarm clock, Taurus! If you've been waiting for the right moment to get back in action, that moment is now. You might also have been procrastinating certain activities that would be good.

Gemini: Your creative spark is ready to break free immediately, but others may not understand it. You could be working on creating a workspace for a hobby that brings you joy, regardless of what it is.

Cancer: You might be hiding from progress. It's possible that you only feel safe in your comfort zone, where you know what will happen next, but this can lead to missing opportunities that would have elevated you past where you are currently.

Leo: What you need to learn and what you know may not match up. You probably feel ready to take on complex challenges, when in reality, there could be a few more lessons for you to learn.

Virgo: A shift might be on the agenda at this time. You may have been trying to follow the same methods for a while, but they continually lead you to the same spot -- where you don't necessarily want to be.

Libra: You might be letting others dictate your life too much. While it's understandable that you want to hear valuable advice from a trusted peer, it's not healthy to hand over the reins of your entire life to someone else.

Scorpio: The snooze button is right there, and you're allowed to use it. You could have been burning the candle at both ends recently, possibly worrying your loved ones regarding your health and habits.

Sagittarius: It might be time to move back from the drama. Your spot in the friend group is potentially sizzling with hot gossip, which could be affecting the way that you think about certain people that you're close to.

Capricorn: Family probably doesn't know what's best for you at this time. Whatever path they're trying to push your future down, you've likely developed a different vision for yourself.

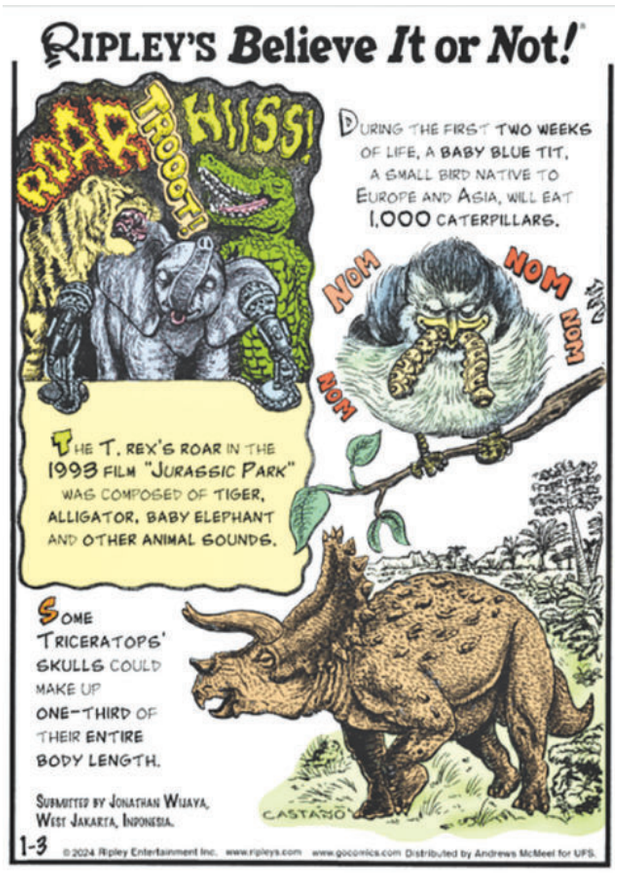
Aquarius: Your intuition might not be lining up with your current knowledge. This may indicate that some information you've been given isn't quite accurate, meaning that miscommunication or deception.

Pisces: Stability doesn't have to be boring. You may feel like you should be in a state of constant evolution, never letting yourself stay still for long, but this can lead to several rough changes that don't truly align.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





APF ladies complete invincible campaign with title win

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Jan. 3



Remaining unbeaten Armed Police Force (APF) Club, the only departmental team in the eight-team T20 tournament, has won the PM Cup Women's National Cricket Tournament.

APF won the final against Koshi Province by 11 runs in front of a decent crowd at the TU International Cricket Ground on Wednesday to lift the trophy after two years. Previously, APF had won the title of PM Cup in 2021 editions.

The dominant APF side struggled the most in the final match to win the tournament. Batting first, APF gave a target of 115 losing seven wickets. In six of the nine matches batted first by APF throughout the campaign, it was the lowest target posted by APF.

Indu Barma was the highest scorer for APF with her third half-century of the edition. She was caught by Namita Shrestha in the first ball of the final over bowled by Apsari Begam and went back to the pavilion scoring 53 runs off 47 balls with six fours and a six.

Opener Jyoti Pandey (27 off 30) and Roma Thapa (14 off 15) were the only batters to score in two digits for APF.

Begam prevented APF from extending the target as she took a hat trick of wickets by dismissing Barma, Nary Thapa and Sonu Khadka in the first three balls of the final over.

Alisha Khadiya took two wickets and Rubina Chhetry and Nisha Shah took a wicket each respectively for Koshi.

However, despite restricting APF to its lowest target in the tournament, Koshi could not win its second title. Koshi had lifted the trophy in 2020.

Chhetry played a captain's inning in the chase but lacked enough support from others to reach the target in 20 overs. Opening the inning for Koshi, Chhetry scored 62 runs off 58 balls with the support of seven fours and a six. It was her third fifty this edition.

Kajal Shrestha was the only second batter for Koshi to score in two digits as the team could only reach 103 runs losing four wickets at the end of 20 overs. Karuna Bhandari and Sita Rana Magar took a wicket each for APF.

For the first time, the tournament was played in a round-robin format with the playoffs, and a final. Koshi had lost to APF by 52 runs in Qualifier 1 for a place in the finals. APF also won against Koshi by eight wickets in the league stage.

Meanwhile, despite losing, Chhetry became the highest scorer in the tournament with 345 runs in 10 innings. APF's Barma, who batted in seven innings, was the second-highest scorer in the tourney with 284 runs.

Chhetry was declared the player of the tournament for her performance with both bat and ball and was given a Yamaha Ray ZR Hybrid 125cc scooter.

Jyotsnika Marasini of Gandaki Province was adjudged as the emerging player in the tournament. Usha Mahato of Madhes Province and Suman Khatiwada of Gandaki Province were awarded as the best bowler and batter respectively.

APF won the cash prize of Rs. 500,000 with the trophy and Koshi received Rs. 300,000 as the runner-up.

Jyoti retires

Jyoti Pandey, the opening batsman and wicketkeeper for the Nepali women's national cricket team, announced her retirement from both national and domestic duties on Wednesday.

She retired after winning the Prime Minister's Cup Women's T20 title for APF, the team she has been playing for since 2011 in domestic cricket. She batted 27 runs in the title victory of APF.



Jyoti made her debut against Pakistan in the ACC Women's Asia Cup held in Thailand in 2016 and has played 17 T20 international matches for Nepal.

After her retirement, she was honoured by the APF team on the field with a guard of honour.

Pakistan fight back to frustrate Australia

AFP
Sydney, Jan. 3

Gritty Pakistan clawed back from looming disaster to finish with 313 on the back of fighting half-centuries from Mohammad Rizwan, Agha Salman and Aamer Jamal on the first day of the third Test against Australia on Wednesday.

The tourists, staring down a meagre innings total at 96 for five after winning the toss, counter-attacked to frustrate the Australians at the Sydney Cricket Ground. Rizwan clubbed 88 off 103 balls, number nine Jamal a spirited 82 off 97 and Salman 53 off 67 to give the tourists some hope after a car-crash start to the innings.

David Warner, playing in his 112th and final Test, had to see off a tense final over before the close and survived a scare before finishing with six in Australia's reply of 6-0.

Australia skipper Pat Cummins took five for 61 for his third successive five-wicket haul in the series.

In a day that began in elation for Australia ended in frustration as Pakistan's tail wagged furiously to rescue their side after a terrible start.

Mohammad Rizwan and Agha Salman triggered the comeback with a spirited 94-run stand to defy the Australia attack. Rizwan, who had been dropped for the first Test, blasted two sixes and 10 fours off 103 balls before he fell to a legside trap set by Cummins.

Rizwan top-edged a pull shot for Josh Hazlewood to take the catch at fine leg after posting the highest individual score by a Pakistan batsman of the series.

Rousing morning

Salman took up the cudgels with a half-century before he was caught by Travis Head off Mitchell Starc.

Jamal kept the fightback going as he registered his highest Test score before he fell to Nathan Lyon.

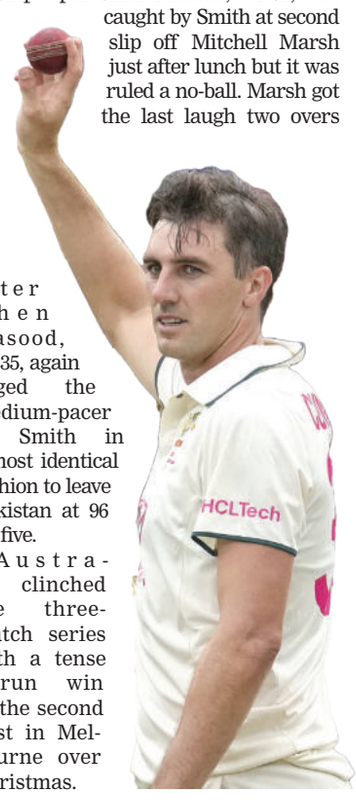
That left Warner to see out the final over of the day and he began with a flourish, cutting the first ball for four from spinner Sajid Khan.

It was a rousing morning session for Australia as openers Abdullah Shafique and debutant Saim Ayub were dismissed inside two overs.

The out-of-form Shafique fell to the second ball of Starc's opening over and Ayub, brought in for Imam-ul-Haq to make his Test debut, only lasted two balls before a Hazlewood outswinger had him caught behind by Alex Carey.

Babar Azam hit three glorious cover drives to the ropes before he was out for 26. Cummins appealed vociferously for lbw but was turned down by the umpire, only to seek a review and get the verdict, leaving the tourists tottering at 39 for three. Saud Shakeel copped a nasty blow on the collarbone from a Cummins lifter and in the Australian skipper's next over he prodded a catch behind to Carey for five, leaving his side further in the mire at 47 for four.

Skipper Shan Masood, on 32, was caught by Smith at second slip off Mitchell Marsh just after lunch but it was ruled a no-ball. Marsh got the last laugh two overs later when Masood, on 35, again edged the medium-pacer to Smith in almost identical fashion to leave Pakistan at 96 for five.



Australia clinched the three-match series with a tense 79-run win in the second Test in Melbourne over Christmas.

INDIA ROUTS S. AFRICA FOR 55

AP
Cape Town, Jan. 3

Mohammed Siraj claimed his best Test figures as South Africa was shot out for just 55 in 23.2 overs on the opening day of the second cricket test against India.

South Africa's paltry total was its lowest since being readmitted to the test arena in 1991.

Paceman Siraj took 6-15 in a stunning nine-over spell as the Proteas collapsed before lunch.

It was his third five-wicket haul in his 23rd test, and his first against South Africa. His previous best was 5-60 against the West Indies in Port of Spain last year.

Jasprit Bumrah also took 2-25 while Mukesh Kumar picked up two wickets without conceding a run in 2.2 overs.

The procession started in the fourth over, with Aiden Markram caught at slip for two.

Paceman Siraj took 6-15 in a stunning nine-over spell as the Proteas collapsed before lunch.

Stand-in skipper Dean Elgar, who scored 185 in the first test at Centurion, was bowled for four as Siraj sent back both openers.

Tony de Zorzi was caught behind and Bumrah sent back debutant Tristan Stubbs for three, caught at short leg.

There was a 19-run partnership for the fifth wicket between David Bedingham and Kyle Verreynne, but it was only a brief respite for the host nation.

Siraj dismissed both batters in the space of 10 deliveries, with Verreynne's 15 the Proteas' top score. In between, he sent back Marco Jansen.

Kumar was introduced later and he took two wickets in 14 deliveries, accounting for Keshav Maharaj and Kagiso Rabada.

Bumrah finished off the innings by having Nandre Burger caught at slip,

South Africa had opted to bat after winning the toss, with Elgar skippering the team in his final test before retirement as Temba Bavuma was ruled out by injury.

The hosts also brought in Maharaj and Lungi Ngidi. India made two changes, recalling Kumar and Ravindra Jadeja.

West Ham and Brighton settle for 0-0 draw

AP
London, Jan. 3



PHOTO: AP
West Ham's Konstantinos Mavropanos, top right, heads the ball during the English Premier League soccer match against Brighton in London.

Defensive-minded West Ham held off late pressure from Brighton to settle for a 0-0 draw that extended its Premier League unbeaten run to four games on Tuesday.

One point was enough for Brighton to climb over Manchester United into seventh place, while the Hammers stayed in sixth.

Both teams were missing starters through injury, illness and suspension. West Ham was also without forward Mohammed Kudus, who was called up by Ghana for the Africa Cup of Nations.

West Ham hasn't allowed a goal in its past four league matches — three of which were victories.

Brighton substitute Jakub Moder blazed a shot over the bar from close range in the 87th minute at London Stadium. The visitors threatened again minutes later but goalkeeper Alphonse Areola stretched to save Adam Lallana's shot from distance.

Just before the hour mark, Brighton's João Pedro beat several defenders but shot straight at Areola.

Tomas Soucek then missed on the other end, shooting wide in the 61st minute after Saïd Benrahma's cross fell to him.

Evan Ferguson provided a spark off the bench for Brighton. The 19-year-old Ireland striker shot just wide shortly after replacing Danny Welbeck.

Brighton midfielder James Milner made his 632nd top-flight appearance to tie Ryan Giggs for second-most in the Premier League. Milner could pass all-time leader Gareth Barry next season.

"It's quite a big number. It's taken a long time," Milner said before the game. "I think it's a nice thing but it's a big game for us tonight. We want to start the year with a win."

The 37-year-old Milner is in his first season at Brighton after eight years with Liverpool. He debuted with Leeds in the 2002-03 season at age 16.

AC Milan reach Cup quarterfinals

Luka Jovi scored two goals to help AC Milan beat Cagliari 4-1 in the Italian Cup on Tuesday.

Milan has won the Italian Cup five times but it last lifted the trophy in 2003 and hasn't reached the final since 2018. The Rossoneri will face either Atalanta or Sassuolo in the quarterfinals.

Milan coach Stefano Pioli was under pressure after a poor run that had seen his team eliminated from the Champions League at the group stage.

The Rossoneri also had a lengthy injury list and rested a number of star players — starting with four teenagers — but hadn't lost to Cagliari at San Siro since 1997.

Jovi opened the scoring in the 29th minute following a delightful assist from Théo Hernandez and the duo combined again shortly before halftime.

The two goals took Jovi's tally to five in his past six matches. It took the Serbia forward until December to score his first goal for Milan after joining from Fiorentina at the start of the season.

Teenager Chaka Traorè extended Milan's lead early in the second half, with his third Rossoneri goal in his first start for the team.

Rafael Leão capped a great night for Milan in stoppage time, shortly after Paolo Azzi netted a consolation for Cagliari.

Getafe lose to Rayo

Mason Greenwood was accused of insulting a referee in the Spanish league on Tuesday, becoming one of three Getafe players sent off in a 2-0 loss to Rayo Vallecano.

The referee said in his post-match report that Greenwood insulted him in the 50th minute with an expletive in English, something that the British player and the Spanish club denied.

"He doesn't speak Spanish very well, he told me that he was saying something else," Getafe coach José Bordalás said in his post-match interview. "He was frustrated because the referee was not calling any fouls on him, but he never offended anyone. It was just a comment that he made."

Referee Jorge Figueroa Vázquez also said in his report that, after being sent off, Greenwood made a gesture pointing to his head and expressing his disagreement with the decision.

Greenwood is playing with Getafe on a loan from Manchester United, which he left at the end of last season following a criminal investigation into a possible attempted rape that was closed by prosecutors.

Getafe also lost defender Damián Suárez for allegedly insulting the assistant referee moments after he was substituted in the 70th.

The hosts had been playing a man down from the 40th after forward Juanmi Latasa was sent off with a second yellow card.

Sergio Camello scored in first-half stoppage time and shortly after halftime to help Rayo end an eight-match winless streak in the Spanish league. The result left Rayo in 11th place. Getafe stayed eighth.

Real Sociedad overcome a red card to its goalkeeper in the first half to salvage a 1-1 home draw against Alaves.

The draw moved Alaves to 15th place, four points from the relegation zone. Sociedad stayed sixth, three points from fifth-place Athletic Bilbao.

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:55 am, Sunset at 5:22 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.2	3.6	0.0
Dipayal	23.7	4.1	0.0
Dhangadi	21.4	8.8	0.0
Birendranagar	22.1	4.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	21.4	7.8	0.0
Jumla	15.4	-6.3	0.0
Ghorahi	21.8	6.0	0.0
Pokhara	19.9	8.1	0.0
Bhairahawa	22.8	6.6	0.0
Simara	23.6	5.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.7	5.4	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.7	7.0	0.0
Taplejung	16.1	4.8	0.0
Dhankuta	22.4	7.8	0.0
Biratnagar	25.2	7.5	0.0
Jomsom	10.0	-4.5	0.0*
Dharan	25.4	11.0	0.0*
Lumle	16.5	5.8	0.0*
Janakpur	25.6	8.0	0.0*
Jiri	14.9	0.4	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 4, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.95	Rs. 133.55
Euro	1	Rs. 145.22	Rs. 145.88
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.83	Rs. 168.59
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.70	Rs. 156.40
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 89.50	Rs. 89.91
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.63	Rs. 100.08
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.11	Rs.100.56
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.31	Rs. 9.35
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.60	Rs. 18.69
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.45	Rs. 35.61
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.47	Rs. 36.64
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.87	Rs. 3.89
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.20	Rs. 36.36
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.71	Rs. 28.84
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.14	Rs. 10.18
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.99	Rs. 13.05
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.47	Rs. 19.56
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.03	Rs. 17.11
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.23	Rs. 434.18
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.67	Rs. 354.26

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54